> In the month of November soon after the commencement of the Coorla cutting, a deputation of native workmen waited upon the contractor with a complaint about the hours of working, which were then from 8 a.m. to 6 p.m. They solicited their master to allow them to begin their day an hour earlier, so that they might leave work before sunset, because at 6 o'clock the water was too cold for them to bathe. [40]

Yet another story states how one day in the 1850s, during the construction of the line, there was a sudden strike by workers due to a lack of assurance on wages: 'One day, the engineer who was engaged at Sion was surprised to observe all the native labourers from the large cutting in that neighbourhood were walking away as no one had assured them of payment. Only when the engineer guaranteed them the wages did they turn around.' [41]

Relations between native labourers, contractors and British engineers remained strained. Conditions worsened when the line reached the difficult Bhore Ghat near the Khandala stretch between Bombay and Pune in the 1850s. This was a tough mountainous stretch, with the worst possible working conditions, leading to wage disputes, illness, injuries, riots, sickness and thousands of deaths, which eventually led the British to enforce a law and despatch a full-fledged police force on the line to handle difficult situations. The Employers' and Workmen's (Disputes) Act (X) implemented in 1860 gave powers to magistrates to settle wage disputes.

Land issues, religious disputes, boundary problems, strikes over hot water and what not! All this, despite the railway planners in India being painstakingly thorough in their work.

Despite all such odds and unpredictable hurdles, the lines were finally ready, up and running, and what came next was another set of complexities —and that too very 'Hindustanee'. Read on to experience the sometimes hilarious and sometimes serious issues the population using the railways in India faced.

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[26] John Chapman, 'Quality of Indian Cotton,' *The Cotton and Commerce of India, Considered in Relation to the Interests of Great Britain with Remarks on Railway Communication in the Bombay Presidency* , London (Jan 1851) chap.1, p.8.

[27] Thomas Williamson, 'Two Letters on the Advantages of Railway Communication in Western India,' Richard and John E. Taylor, eds., Fleet Street, 1846

[28] *Railways in India; Being Four Articles Reprinted from the Railway Register for July, August, September, and November, 1845* (London: Madden And Malcom, 1845)